

Concept tags for work in Week 8: Ugly Darlings, iteration at scale, design with intent, emotionally durable design, one resonant idea

In class this week we talked about “ugly darlings/ducklings,” focusing on variation and iterating as a vital part of the design process. As Catmull puts it and as we discussed theories for this week, “The discipline is holding the tension between “this isn’t working yet” and “there’s something here worth saving.” This is what I looked for as I worked through my final project. I went through several iterations of the design for my web apps interface. On the outside, this might seem like a simple aesthetics concern; what colors to choose? How should I display the projects that get uploaded to the site? However, the issue went deeper than that for me. My original Canva design (as seen in this week's slides & in my “detailed v2” tab here), was full of color and patterns. I liked the design, but I didn’t love it. I even tried to upload it to Claude Code and see what the interactive elements would look like with this draft, but I just could not imagine students using the site.

This week I had to take a hard look at what I had designed and strip many of the elements I originally thought gave the site personality but really just made the page look busy. I wanted this to be a site that made everybody feel welcome and designed so that the projects were the main attraction. I still liked having the frames and the floating landscape of the site to feel like a museum gallery and leave in some of that quirky personality I was going for. This is when I came up with the idea to use Dartmouth’s colors to emphasize who this website was made for and leave the gold frames as the focal point.

While I may have originally been hesitant to let my first iteration of the design go, this really opened the door for more ideas and variations of my original concept. By adding more of Dartmouth’s green, that gave me the idea to add the pop of color as a side bar that would serve as the navigation tool for users. Ideas only ever kept flowing after that.

See critiques and variation between v1 and v2 in the next tab!